

Philosophies And Values Guiding The Student Affairs Professional

This chapter examines four philosophies: rationalism, empiricism, pragmatism, and postmodernism. They are presented in chronological order, from the oldest to the newest. These philosophies are not new to higher education, but they guide student affairs practice. The hope is to deepen our understanding of our thoughts and activities as student affairs administrators and educators.

Student affairs are part of higher education, and higher education must have some core values and mission. Like any other philosophy, student affairs seek the truth in its practice. There are three central philosophical issues discussed: metaphysics, epistemology, and axiology. The book discusses truth and virtue in more detail. As with any theory of practice, all four philosophies address the nature of reality. “What is ultimately real?” is the basic question asked. Student affairs is an educational practice in higher education, and therefore it must answer such questions as “What is true?” and “How do we know?” and thereby make better decisions.

Traditionally, truth and virtue are considered inseparable. During a “premodern” era of philosophy, truth is an absolute principle of one’s religious faith. Most of higher education has separated the question of truth from the certainty of faith.

Most of higher education involves modern and postmodern philosophy. Modern philosophy focuses on logic and evidence. It idealizes objectivity and verifies subjectivity. Its advocates say, “seeing is believing.” Postmodern philosophy emphasizes the subjective context of any object. Its advocates argue, “believing is seeing.”

The book outlines each philosophy into four categories that include 1) assumptions, 2) institutional identity, 3) practices and roles, and 4) relationship to student affairs.

Rationalism

The philosophy is rooted in the teachings of Plato and Aristotle. The belief is that humans have mental ability and the best thinkers are the best of human beings. The sole aim of education is to cultivate reason (pg. 90). The truth is everywhere the same. For this reason, education should be the same everywhere. It also believes that universal truths exist and that time reveals which endure. The best source of eternal truths is classical literature, because it has passed the test of time.

Rationalist values only the student’s mind.

Empiricism

The belief is that experience, especially of the senses, is the only source of knowledge. The term “empirical” means “under test”; truth is attached to statements that agree with the observed facts of sensory life. The value of any truth is proportionate to the amount of evidence that supports it. The view that experience, especially of the senses, is the only source of knowledge.

In contrast to the rationalist, it says, “We know because we have reasoned out the solution.” The empiricist argues, “We know because we have observed it, i.e., seen it, heard it, touched it (sensory experience).”

Two kinds of truths:

- 1) Can be verified by experience – involve sensory data that led to scientific research
- 2) Help analyze experience – involve theories, mathematical formulas, and the like that led to logical positivism.

Pragmaticism

Pragmatic truth is what works. William James said, “True ideas are those that we can assimilate, validate, corroborate, and verify. False ideas are those that we can’t.

The assumption is individually constructed. The learner is self-directed in his/her learning process. The learner’s experience is the center of the educational process, but experience by itself is not necessarily educational. It has to be contemplated and reconstructed in order to increase a person’s ability to direct subsequent experiences

Pragmatism is the child of empiricism, and it shares its parent’s distrust of thought without observation. But traditional empiricism looks backward for the causes of ideas, while pragmatism looks forward to their impact on experience.

Experience became educational when it met the conditions of interaction and continuity. It has to interact with a person’s inner thoughts and social behavior, and it affects the good life. Lifelong learning is implicit in this conception of educational experience.

Four common beliefs about student affairs:

1. Belief in the worth of the individual
2. Belief in equal dignity of thinking and feeling, and working
3. Belief in the world has a place for everybody
4. The belief that an individual’s experiences continue over time represents a concept of continuity (Dewey).

Postmodernism

Postmodernism is influenced by pragmatism. The philosophy is dominated by both French and German influences. Another name for postmodernism is called “Continental Philosophy”.

Like pragmatists, postmodernists center experience in the human context, but they contend that the individual is deeply related to social power. It favors socially constructed education, lifelong learning, informal experiences, and multicultural education.

Some principles of postmodernism (pg. 95):

- There is no objective, permanent world “out there”; everything is subject and relative.
- Therefore, knowledge does not exist without context.
- Because everything is contextual, caring is an essential characteristic of the human condition, and caring ranges from simple interest in others to deep solicitude for them.
- The repetition of words, structures, and actions creates a false sense of objectivity and sustains economic, political, and social hegemony.
- The apparent structures built by repetition need to be deconstructed to review their subjective essence.
- This revelation cannot be revealed through purely intellectual means; truth is revealed intuitively.

	Rationalism	Empiricism	Pragmatism	Postmodernism
Beliefs	▪ Mental ability ▪ Universal truths exist, and time reveals which truths endure	▪ Acquisition of knowledge ▪ Sensory experiences ▪ Knowledge derives from experience ▪ Scientific knowledge – fundamentally whole and one.	▪ Truth is what works. ▪ The world has a place for everybody	▪ Objective representative of reality
Assumptions	▪ Education is to cultivate reason. ▪ Education implies teaching. ▪ Teaching implies knowledge. ▪ Knowledge is truth. ▪ 1) Reading, 2) writing, and 3) deductive reasoning	▪ Inductive reasoning--collections of facts ▪ Can be verified by experience ▪ Help analyze experience	▪ Individually constructed ▪ Experience-centered	▪ Education is for everyone.
Institutional Identity	▪ Liberal Arts education ▪ Teaching ▪ Community of scholars	▪ Liberal Arts education ▪ Research (rationalism: research application; empiricism: research new method)	▪ Need for society ▪ State University and community college	▪ Open access ▪ Students and faculty exchange knowledge
Practices and Roles	▪ Teaching ▪ Teacher-centered institution ▪ Lectures are means for transmitting information and Socratic dialogues are the means for debating it.	▪ Pure scientific research (teaching takes the back seat)	▪ Building a new social order, schools leading ▪ Research is “applied” instead of “pure” ▪ Student-centered ▪ Teaching focuses on learning instead of the activities. ▪ Students are not passive receptacles of knowledge, but the central factor in a learner-centered approach. ▪ Faculty are supported to provide courses that students want to take	▪ Learning is emphasized ▪ Educational process begins from the ground up instead of the top down ▪ Peer-based learning communities ▪ Faculty and Students do not identify with the institution but with subcultures
Relationship with Student Affairs	▪ Identify capable students -- recruit students to campus ▪ Teaching and research (student services are extracurricular [pg. 91]) ▪ Help students learn how to be good people and committed to the common good [4] ▪ Discipline in this college is not just punishment, but a means of developing character [5]	▪ Administration orientation ▪ Services are specialized	▪ Student-oriented ▪ Student Personnel Point of View ([SPPOV, 1937] American Council on Education)	▪ Support everyone ▪ Support all subcultures (women, Latinos, Black, White,)
People	▪ Taylor, 1952 ▪ Hutchin, 1967 ▪ Conant, 1964 ▪ Boyer, 1995 ▪ Rhatigan, 1978	▪ Conant, 1964 ▪ Sloan, 1980 ▪ Martin, 1982 ▪ Lloyd-Jones, 1952 ▪ Blimling, 2001	▪ Charles Peirce ▪ William James ▪ Boller, 1980 ▪ Dewey, 1971 ▪ Brubacher, 1962 ▪ Baham, 1980	▪ Adam, Bell & Griffin, 1997 ▪ Birnbaum, 1988 ▪ Bolman, Deal, 1991